

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN ERITREA

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

When workers at the Bisha mine sought justice for the coerced labour documented at and around it, they could not turn to any court or advocate inside Eritrea — so they turned outward, and pursued the foreign mining company that ran the mine in its own home courts abroad, in a landmark international lawsuit the company ultimately settled. That case is the truest picture of environmental and resource accountability in Eritrea: it happens from outside. Eritrea is one of the most closed and tightly controlled states in the world — no free press, no independent civil society, no space for the open domestic advocacy this series usually describes — a Horn-of-Africa nation whose economy is increasingly built on mining, where an indefinite national-service program has been documented by the United Nations and human-rights organisations as a source of conscript labour at and around the mines. Its highland terraces, Red-Sea coast, and Danakil desert bear the marks of the mines, the scarce water, and the sea, but its people have almost no safe, open avenue to defend that environment from within. There is no safe domestic movement to promise — and the protection of anyone inside is the first, last, and governing principle of everything that follows.

Those who would hold Eritrea's mining and environment to account cannot do so inside, but the external tools are real, as the Bisha lawsuit showed. The distinctive lever is **corporate accountability**: the foreign companies that run the mines can be held to account — for the coerced labour, for the environmental harm — through their home-country courts and the international frameworks, as the landmark case proved. The **international courts, frameworks, and human-rights bodies** reach where domestic advocacy cannot. **Scientific and satellite monitoring** can see and document what the closed state hides — the mines, the land, the water. The **Red Sea and the Dahlak** can be protected through international marine cooperation. And the **large Eritrean diaspora** carries testimony, documentation, and advocacy from safety, while **rigorous documentation**, gathered only from those safely outside, grounds it all. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. Eritrea is one of the world's most closed and repressive states, where there is no safe domestic space of any kind and exposure can bring the gravest consequences to a person and their family, so the work must be conducted wholly from outside. The mining is the economy, and its labour documented as coerced. The greening of the land is real, yet built on that same coerced labour — an honesty this guide keeps. No swift or landmark domestic victory, and no safe domestic movement, is to be promised. And, above all, no one inside can be exposed. So the work must be wholly external, corporate-accountability and international framed, neutral on the government's politics while honest about the documented realities, and protecting every person inside above all else — and the honest prize is the mining and its labour held to account, the harm documented, and the sea protected from outside, not a movement built within.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot build a movement inside one of the world's most repressive states, and you must never ask anyone to try. What can be done — and has been done — is to act from outside: hold the foreign mining companies to account in their home courts and the international frameworks, as the Bisha case did; use the international courts and human-rights bodies; document the hidden harm through science and satellite; protect the Red Sea through international cooperation; and work through the diaspora — while protecting every person inside above all else.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Eritrea is the most closed setting in this guide, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. This is not a fight you win inside — there is no safe domestic space of any kind. It is a wholly external effort whose realistic prize is the mining and its labour held to account, the hidden harm documented, and the sea protected from outside — not a domestic movement. Enter it understanding that no cause is worth the safety of a single person inside, that testimony comes only from those safely outside, and that protecting everyone inside is the absolute and overriding consideration of every step.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power rests wholly with a closed and controlling state, and there is no domestic system to reach. The decisions resisters can influence are external — taken in the **foreign companies** that run the mines and their **home-country courts and regulators**, in the **international courts, frameworks, and human-rights bodies**, in the **scientific and satellite monitors** who see what the state hides, and in the **international marine bodies and the diaspora**. These, from outside, are who can act.

How a Decision Is Actually Made — and Where You Jump In

The mining, the land programs, and the coastal projects advance under the closed state's total control; there is no safe domestic hearing. Resisters enter where the outside world touches the harm: the foreign mine companies' accountability in their home jurisdictions, the international frameworks that bind them, the satellite and scientific record of the hidden harm, the marine cooperation over the Red Sea. Each is a point of leverage reached from outside — as the landmark lawsuit reached the company that ran Bisha.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the mines: which foreign companies run them, where those companies are based and listed, and what labour and environmental standards their home jurisdictions and financiers enforce. Follow the labour: how the documented coerced national-service labour connects to the mines. Follow the sea: what the Red Sea and its reefs need, and which international marine bodies engage. The leverage lies in the foreign companies, the international courts and frameworks, and the monitored record.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Inside Eritrea, no independent watcher exists. The watchers resisters can engage are external: the foreign companies' home courts and regulators, the international human-rights and labour bodies, the resource and supply-chain frameworks, the scientific and satellite monitors, the international marine bodies, and the diaspora. These are the institutions a wholly external case is built to reach.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Eritrean effort yields a domestic "win," and honesty requires saying so — there is no safe domestic space. What the external tools realistically deliver is accountability and documentation: a foreign mine company held to account for coerced labour or environmental harm, as the Bisha case showed; the hidden harm seen and recorded by satellite and science; the Red Sea raised through international cooperation. The single most decisive move is **holding the foreign mining companies to account through their home courts and the international frameworks**, because they are reachable where the state is not, and

because a landmark lawsuit has already proven it can be done. Corporate accountability is the distinctive lever; the international courts and monitoring the reach; the diaspora the safe carrier. Nothing here is fast or domestic — but the outside levers are real and proven.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the coerced labour at the mines, the environmental damage, the threat to the water or the Red Sea. **Which foreign company runs it?** — and where is it based, listed, and financed. **Which external lever does it touch?** — corporate accountability, international courts, satellite monitoring, marine cooperation. **Who outside can act?** — the home-country courts and regulators, the human-rights and labour bodies, the diaspora. **How is everyone inside kept safe?** — the overriding question, answered by keeping all work external and exposing no one. Pick the harm where the foreign company and the external handle are clearest and safest.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, all gathered safely from outside. **Layer one: the harm** — the coerced labour documented through those safely outside and the international bodies, the environmental damage by satellite and science. **Layer two: the company and the framework** — the foreign mine operators, their home jurisdictions, and the labour, human-rights, and environmental standards they answer to. **Layer three: the channel and the protection** — which court, framework, or monitor to reach, and the absolute rule that no person inside is named, exposed, or endangered, and that testimony comes only from those safely outside. A case built on satellite imagery, the foreign companies' own accountability, and safely-gathered testimony is one that reaches the levers without endangering anyone.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the satellite imagery of the mines and the land, the environmental data, and the coerced-labour documentation from the UN, human-rights bodies, and those safely outside. Gather the **company record**: the foreign operators, their home jurisdictions, their financiers, and the standards they answer to. Gather the **framework record**: the international courts, the labour and human-rights bodies, the resource and marine frameworks. Gather the **channel record**: the home-country courts and regulators, the international bodies, the diaspora networks. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm every source is external and safe, and no one inside exposed.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE EXTERNAL AND DIASPORA COALITION

The coalition here is wholly external, because it must be. Build it from the **international human-rights, labour, and corporate-accountability organisations** that can reach the foreign mine companies; the **home-country lawyers and courts** where those companies are based, as the Bisha case used; the **scientific and satellite monitors** who document the hidden harm; the **international marine bodies** for the Red Sea; and the **Eritrean diaspora**, who carry testimony and advocacy from safety. Build carefully, protect every source, gather testimony only from those safely outside, and never in a way that draws in or exposes anyone inside.

STEP 4: CORPORATE-ACCOUNTABILITY, COURT & MONITORING LEVERS — CONTESTING THE HARM FROM OUTSIDE

Set expectations honestly: the levers are external, indirect, and often slow, and the state is closed, so the prize is accountability and documentation, not a domestic stop.

The Corporate Accountability

The distinctive lever is **corporate accountability**: the foreign companies that run the mines can be held to account — for the coerced labour and the environmental harm — through their home-country courts, regulators, and financiers, and the international frameworks. The Bisha lawsuit proved this is genuinely usable from outside. Trace the harm to the company and press it where it is reachable.

The International Courts and Monitoring

The **international courts, human-rights and labour bodies, and frameworks** reach where domestic advocacy cannot, and **scientific and satellite monitoring** can see and record what the closed state hides — the mines, the land, the water. Use them to establish and raise the harm.

The Red Sea and the Diaspora

The **Red Sea and the Dahlak** can be protected through international marine cooperation, and the **diaspora** carries testimony, documentation, and advocacy from safety. Pursued together — the corporate accountability, the courts and monitoring, and the marine cooperation and diaspora — these external levers hold the mining to account and document the harm, while every person inside is protected absolutely.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the foreign company's home court or regulator**: here is coerced labour or environmental harm at a mine your company runs, and the standard it breaches. **For the international human-rights and labour bodies**: here is the documented coerced labour behind the mining. **For the scientific and marine bodies**: here is the hidden harm the satellites show, and the Red Sea at stake. **For the diaspora and the world**: here is a closed state's mining, held to account from outside. **The golden rule**: keep everything external and safe, argue corporate accountability and documented harm, gather testimony only from those safely outside, and protect every person inside absolutely.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media matters, carried entirely from outside. Frame the story around **the mines, the labour, and the accountability**: a closed state's mining built on documented coerced labour, and the foreign companies that can be held to account for it, as the Bisha case showed. Carry it through international investigative, human-rights, and business-accountability outlets, and the diaspora networks. A few cautions govern everything: never name or endanger anyone inside; rely on satellite imagery, the international record, and safely-gathered testimony; keep it factual and neutral on the politics while honest about the documented realities; and let the corporate accountability and the monitored harm carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message external, documentary, and absolutely protective of anyone inside.

8A — To a foreign mine company's home court or regulator: present the coerced labour or environmental harm at a mine it runs, and the standard breached.

8B — To an international human-rights or labour body: set out the documented coerced labour behind the mining and request engagement.

8C — To a corporate-accountability organisation: present the company, the harm, and the home-jurisdiction handle, drawing on the Bisha precedent.

8D — To a scientific or satellite monitor: request the imagery and data on the hidden mining and land harm.

8E — To an international marine body: flag the Red Sea and Dahlak stakes and request cooperation.

8F — To a financier of the mine company: ask how the financing meets the institution's labour and environmental standards.

8G — To the diaspora networks: share the case and ask for testimony (from those safely outside) and amplification.

8H — To the international public: summarise the mining, the coerced labour, and the external accountability, and ask for pressure — never exposing anyone inside.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: identify the foreign company running the mine and its home jurisdiction; pull the satellite imagery and the international coerced-labour record; write the one-page corporate-accountability case. **The fastest-moving levers:** the foreign company's home court or regulator, the human-rights and labour bodies, and the satellite monitoring. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the corporate-accountability and human-rights organisations and the diaspora first — they act safely from outside. Throughout, gather testimony only from those safely outside, and expose no one inside.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but closed and total: the state controls everything, and there is no safe domestic space. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not a domestic stop, but accountability and documentation through the external levers. Lean on the corporate accountability, the international courts and frameworks, the satellite monitoring, and the diaspora, all from outside. And accept the honest limits — the mining is the economy, the labour coerced, the greening built on that same coercion, and progress slow — while still holding the companies to account and documenting the harm, and protecting, always and above all, every person inside.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Here the harm is systemic: a closed state whose economy runs on mining built with documented coerced labour, controlled from the top. Respond only through the **external channels:** the foreign companies' home courts and regulators, the international human-rights and labour bodies, the frameworks, the documented record. Never through domestic action. **On safety and protection:** this governs everything absolutely. Eritrea is one of the world's most closed and repressive states, where there is no safe domestic space and exposure can bring the gravest consequences to a person and their family. Work only through the

foreign-company, international, court, scientific, and diaspora channels, and only from outside; never involve, name, expose, or endanger anyone inside; gather testimony only from those safely outside; and treat the safety of every person inside as the absolute and overriding consideration of every step. Protection is not one concern among others — it is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, all from outside. The documented harm feeds the corporate-accountability case, the international-court and human-rights engagement, and the marine cooperation at once; the external and diaspora coalition organises alongside; the media carries the mining-and-accountability frame throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, identify the foreign company and assemble the satellite and international-record documentation; **months two to six**, engage the home-country courts and regulators, the human-rights and labour bodies, and the marine cooperation; **beyond**, sustain the external accountability and documentation. The core discipline: wholly external, corporate-accountability framed, and absolute in protecting every person inside.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Eritrea is the most closed ground in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a domestic movement can be built, or that there is any safe space inside, or that a swift victory exists — none of that is true, and exposure can bring the gravest consequences. What it claims is narrower and real, and proven: that the foreign companies which run the mines can be held to account — for coerced labour and environmental harm — through their home courts and the international frameworks, as the landmark Bisha lawsuit showed; that the international courts, human-rights bodies, and satellite monitoring can establish and raise the hidden harm; that the Red Sea can be protected through international cooperation; and that the diaspora can carry it all — every step from outside, without ever exposing a single person inside. The levers are external, slow, and partial, and the prize is accountability and documentation, not a domestic stop. But for one of the world's most closed states, whose mining is reachable through the companies that run it, that wholly external, accountability-framed, protective work is not a lesser ambition — it is the only responsible and effective one.